

Gangs Violence Matrix- Case Study (2749 words without references)

1. Summary and Framing

This report critically examines the ethical implications of the Metropolitan Police Service (MPS) Gangs Violence Matrix (GVM), commonly known as the Gangs Matrix. The motivation behind this project was to make an intelligence system that identifies, tracks, and assesses individuals suspected of being involved in gangs in London, UK. Based on their perceived “propensity of violence”, an automated harm score (categorized as red, amber or green) was assigned (Amnesty International, 2018).

In August 2011, riots across London caused massive civil unrest, becoming the trigger for the introduction of Gangs Matrix in February 2012. What initially appeared to be a risk-management tool for the MPS, in practice became a racially discriminatory system. The project was overseen centrally by the Trident Gang Command and managed locally by police and local authorities across London's 32 boroughs (Amnesty International, 2018).

Gangs Matrix database was comprised of diverse data, including police intelligence reports on past arrests, convictions, incidents of violence and weapons access, which were fed by partner agencies (e.g., schools, youth clubs), and social media monitoring through platforms like YouTube, Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, and Snapchat. The individuals recorded on this database were referred to as “gang nominals” (Amnesty International, 2018).

Through several ethical lenses, this report argues that the Matrix’s concept of “social good” was narrow and that real-world harms far outweigh any unclear benefits. It touches on the ethical violations and impact it had on marginalized communities, its data governance principles and, conclude with practical recommendations for ethical improvement.

1. Conceptualization of Good and Harms

Intended Social Impact and "Whose Social Good"

The stated objective of the Gangs Matrix was to contribute to public safety by identifying and targeting "the most harmful gang-affiliated offenders" to prevent serious violence and tackle gang-related crime (MOPAC, 2018). Proponents argued that the Matrix allowed finite resources to be prioritized toward high-risk individuals, thereby reducing homicides and protecting vulnerable youth. However, this came at the expense of a specific demographic. As of October 2017, the database monitored 3,806 individuals; 87% were from Black, Asian, and minority ethnic (BAME) backgrounds, 78% were Black and 80% between age 12-24. 35% of individuals on the database had never even committed a serious offence. The "gang nominal" label affected their education, housing, and employment, with families facing eviction threats even if a relative was on the matrix, punishing them for unproven associations (Amnesty International, 2018; Metropolitan Police Service, 2024; Liberty, 2022; Cresto-Dina, 2023).

Through the lens of ethical theories:

- **Utilitarianism (Consequentialism):** The project's motivation is rooted deeply with the principle of utilitarianism which holds an action as right, as long as it leads to a maximum overall happiness, greater good or positive outcome. The Met police and government agencies likely justify Gangs Matrix by arguing that, despite potential individual hardships, leads to a net reduction of violent crimes, maximizing societal happiness, and greater overall good for a number of people in London. It cares about the consequences of the matrix deployment, which is a safer city as the measure of its ethical rightness.
- **Deontology (Kantian Ethics):** Through a deontological perspective, there is a strong argument that the police are just fulfilling their duty of protecting citizens and enforcing laws. As long as it adheres to their moral principles, any instrument to achieve it looks fair. However, the Amnesty report findings suggest that they failed in upholding such duties universally. Furthermore, Kant's Formula of Humanity was

violated as individuals were treated merely as data points or potential threats to be managed for the benefit of others, rather than as autonomous beings with inherent dignity.

- **Rights-based Ethics:** While we can argue that the project's aim of public safety is the citizen's right to security, the question is at what cost. What about the fundamental rights of specific individuals and groups on their right to privacy and non-discrimination? This raises conflicts about which rights are to be prioritized, the collective right to safety or individual rights.

Ethical Risk Assessment Toolkit

By using Data Hazard Labels toolkit, the ethical risks can be highlighted under these labels:

- a) **Reinforces Existing Biases:** In July 2016, 87% of those listed were from BAME backgrounds, with 78% being Black, far exceeding their share of London population (13%) and those identified in serious youth violence cases (27%). This reflects over-identification of BAME individuals as gang members, resulting in increased policing, more stop and search, and deeper involvement in the criminal justice system (Amnesty International, 2018). As argued in "The Numbers Don't Speak for Themselves", data are not neutral or objective but shaped by social and political contexts; the Gangs Matrix fails to consider these factors, leading to reinforce and amplify existing societal biases (D'Ignazio and Klein, 2020).
- b) **Risk to Privacy:** Data was extensively collected through social media monitoring, with report clearly mentioning that there were instances where officers reportedly set up "fake personas" for covert surveillance without obtaining the legally required Regulation of Investigatory Powers Act (RIPA) warrants, which was a clear demonstration of the lack of safeguards in data sharing where sensitive personal information was spread without the individual's knowledge or consent, violating their autonomy and privacy rights (Amnesty International, 2018).
- c) **Lacks Community Involvement:** The amnesty report strongly suggests that GVM was developed and implemented without meaningful input and consultation

from the communities it claims to serve. This lack of involvement became the reason behind the system's ineffectiveness and failure to identify real issues of violence, instead causing stigmatization of youth culture, shaking up trust and confidence towards the police.

- d) **Ranks or Classifies People:** The core function of the Gangs Matrix was to assign individuals a "harm score" based on their perceived "propensity for violence". This classification based on vague criteria and potentially biased data caused serious consequences like increased policing, prosecution, and social exclusion.

Sociological Framework:

I researched about a social-scientific conceptual framework called **Critical Race Theory** (CRT) which suggests that GVM was a manifestation of institutional racism (Beresford, 2024). CRT tenets, such as the "intercentricity of race", explains how "Blackness" continues to be weaponized at the level of governance and how the Matrix equated it with "gang association". The "gang" label ceased to be a description of criminal activity and became a racialized category applied to urban subculture (Amnesty International, 2018; Waller, 2024).

Power Dynamics theory highlights how GVM reflects institutional biases by enabling a top-down approach where police (people at power) defined "good" and one-sidedly defined the concept of 'gang' without consulting communities affected.

2. Communities Engagement

The GVM was characterized by a lack of participatory approaches, viewing communities as subjects to be managed rather than partners (Amnesty International, 2018). Using Arnstein's Ladder of Participation, the project would likely fall into the lowest rung (Arnstein, 1969):

Non-participation (Manipulation and Therapy): The Met framed the Matrix as a "safeguarding" tool. However, the case study of 'Paul' demonstrated, even a Youth Ambassador for gang prevention remained on the Matrix secretly for years (Amnesty International, 2018). Its portrayal also seems like therapy (cure from gang affiliation) rather than genuine power-sharing.

As highlighted above, the Matrix operated in secret where individuals were not informed about their inclusion, nor given means to challenge their scores (Liberty, 2022). So, “Informing” seems out of question.

Benefits and Limitations of Engagement

A clear dialogue involving communities, especially young and local experts can lead to more nuanced, accurate and culturally sensitive definitions of “gangs” and reduce arbitrary inclusions. Greater participation mitigates inherent bias in data collection and scoring, leading to a fairer system while building trust and confidence on law enforcement, encouraging cooperation and participation in violence prevention efforts.

The downside of engagement is that the law enforcement agencies may have strong case to argue that involvement of communities can compromise intelligence gathering and operational effectiveness. It can also be difficult to ensure true representation from diverse communities. Furthermore, the existing power imbalance makes it challenging to achieve genuine influence not just tokenism.

Specific Communities to Engage and How

The project should prioritize engagement with:

- Wrongly affected BAME youth.
- Community activists and youth workers with deep knowledge of local dynamics and trust within the communities.
- Families of individuals on the matrix to understand what impacts they have experienced.
- Civil Organizations and legal aid groups who ensure rights are protected.

Some ways to engage would be:

- Co-design Workshops where community members are involved in developing definitions, criteria, and oversight mechanisms.

- Establishing independent review board with decision-making power demanding justification for every inclusion, moving towards “Partnership” or “Delegated Power” on Arnstein’s Ladder.
- Introduce a clear, user-friendly process for individuals to challenge their inclusion and periodic reviews.
- Be transparent about the assessment process, demographic breakdowns and metrics.

3. Data Governance and Legal Concerns

Data Governance Principles

Through a newspaper article, I read about the 2018 Information Commissioner’s Office (ICO) investigation, which found the GVM in multiple serious breaches of Data Protection Act 2018/GDPR (ICO, 2018). The ICO pointed out that the Matrix failed to distinguish between victims and offenders, and there was inappropriate data sharing with other public bodies (Mohdin, 2018). The MPS had to agree to address these concerns showcasing that the actual governance was retrospective and reactive, not proactive. In terms of data governance principles outlined by the UK GDPR (UK GDPR, Article 5), I would propose:

- **Lawfulness and transparency:** Directly address the secrecy and lack of clarity of GVM. Mandate that individuals (or parents) are informed when they become “nominals”.
- **Purpose and retention limitation:** 64% of individuals retained on the matrix were at low/zero risk of gang activity and personal data retained longer than necessary, even after removal from the system under ‘gang associates’ (Information Commissioner’s Office, 2018). Only data strictly necessary and relevant to the stated purpose should be collected and retained.
- **Accuracy, Accountability and Oversight:** Victims were misclassified as gang members due to inconsistent definitions for ‘gang membership’ (ICO, 2018). Establish a responsible independent body to review the Matrix’s operations regularly,

correct incorrect or outdated information and introduce right to rectification and erasure.

- **Security and confidentiality:** Address poor data security by ensuring data encryption and secure transfer protocols.

Two questions that I would ask the lawyer regarding the legal concerns are:

- a) **“Given that about 87% of those listed on the matrix were from BAME backgrounds (with 78% black), does this significant overrepresentation constitute indirect discrimination under the Equality Act 2010, and what responsibilities does the police have to prevent this?”**

This question is raised because the core ethical and legal concern of the case study is based around the fact that the Matrix’s outcomes are racially discriminatory. I want to know from a legal perspective about the vulnerability of the project and how its discriminatory impacts can lead to legal challenges and compel the MPS to fundamentally reform or dismantle the matrix. If the MPS have breached equality law then they should be held accountable and made to consider what impacts they have caused to the affected communities and how are they planning to address it.

- b) **“Highlighting the report’s findings, it was found that police officers reportedly used ‘fake personas’ on social media for covert surveillance of suspected gang members without obtaining warrants under the RIPA, what are the legal consequences for the Met police and those involved? What message do the public get if law makers are the ones breaking the law? How are they planning to compensate the individuals whose data have been collected through such underhanded means?”**

This question is to seek clarity on the direct allegations of unlawful data collection practices adopted by the police. It is a serious issue because this is a breach of privacy rights and criminal conduct as well. Just because the ambition is believed to be of greater good, should not mean that they are allowed to perform illegal means to achieve that. A

lawyer's answer would clarify the means to hold accountable for such actions and way to compensate the affected individuals, reinforcing the importance of adherence to legal frameworks even for intelligence gathering.

4. Recommendations

Based on the discussions so far, I would put forward these two recommendations for improving the Gangs Matrix from an ethical perspective:

a) **Implement Transparent Community Oversight:** Collaborate with sociologists, ethicists and community representatives (e.g., youth workers, civil society, ex-offenders) towards developing and implementing a continuous audit framework for the Gangs Matrix, which should:

- **Quantify Bias:** Regularly analyze the matrix demographics against real population and crime data to identify any unfair over-representation.
- **Review indicators:** Identify and update the indicators to exclude factors not directly related to violence (for instance, social media activities) for inclusion and scoring and, indicators which contribute towards the over-representation of BAME individuals and reflect culture rather than actual crime.
- **Develop Alternative, Objective Criteria:** Current criteria are too vague and emotion-based rather than facts. Therefore, based on the audit, propose clearer, fairer, evidence-based alternative criteria for identifying gang involvement and risk, developed in consultation with affected communities and experts.
- **Be Transparent:** Regularly publish anonymized findings for independent oversight.

b) **Design and Introduce “Right to Explanation and Challenge” mechanism:** Integrate a user-friendly digital and non-digital mechanism within the Gangs Matrix system that allows individuals to:

- **Be Notified:** Formally request to know if they are on the matrix.

- **Receive an Explanation:** If included, individuals should have the right to receive clear understandable explanation of why they were added, including the key criteria and data used, while prioritizing individual rights without compromising operational security.
- **Submit an Appeal:** Formally challenge their inclusion or the accuracy of the data used against them, providing counter-evidence or supporting explanations.
- **Track Progress:** Provision to track the status of their appeal through a transparent progression system, with clear timelines for review and decision-making by an independent body.

5. Personal Reflection and Weightage

I would like you to consider the following weights for the assignment criteria:

- Criterion A (Report Structure): 15%
- Criterion B (Knowledge): 25%
- Criterion C (Critical Engagement): 25%
- Criterion D (Theory connection): 20%
- Criterion E (Poster): 10%
- Criterion F (Self-reflection): 5%

Justification:

Criterion B and C hold the highest weight (25%) because the point of this coursework was not to provide mere descriptions of the case study, but deeper, analytical presentations of the underlying ethical implications and link theories to real issues. I questioned the stated objectives, scrutinized evidence and considered alternative perspectives. My knowledge of ethical theories along with ethical risk tools have revolved around the case study, with proper identification of issues aided by relevant references obtained through independent research from sources presented in and out of the lecture.

Criteria D is the bridge between the theories and the real-world impacts of the Gangs Matrix. I have dissected the case study through various relevant ethical and sociological frameworks like Utilitarianism and Deontological perspectives, and the portrayal of Power Dynamics, by drawing specific examples from the Amnesty Report and connecting them to lecture concepts, supporting my weight assignment of 20%.

Criteria A is assigned 15% as it is about structuring and organizing the findings with clear communication of message. As long as there is logical flow and clear topic allocation with relevant message to be conveyed, it's just a frame supplemented by other portions.

Criteria E and F are 10% and 5% respectively not because they are unimportant, but because breadth of analysis is the core task so, critical analysis is more important than perfect wording.

Reflection on Participatory Approach

Both these portions were mentioned as mandatory in the coursework specifications, I did not have any power to go against this. The tutor exercised their power to impose this on me. The default weights were an option but could have resulted in lower marks. In my opinion, this is more like a constrained participation. Under certain constraints, it gave me some influence over how I'd be graded and what aspect of my report I'd like to be focused more on. If I compare my situation to the case study, as with the Matrix, an authoritative body holds power over me, but I have been given a level of input power unlike the communities affected by the Matrix. In Arnstein's ladder terms, this constitutes more like "placation" where I can express my preferences and input into what portion I would like the tutor to prioritize but ultimately no real-decision making power.

This influenced a lot in how I approached my assignment because it made me more conscious on what parts I should prioritize while writing. This granted me a sense that I have been given a voice to speak and a small power to possibly sway the final output (marks) in my favor.

6. References

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Declaration of AI Use

I have used AI while undertaking the assignment in the following ways:

- To support my use of language – YES

I used generative AI not for consultation of ideas or interpretations of the case study, instead I used it to polish my sentences, making it more concise and clearer so that I was not wasting word counts for my report. There were instances where I was writing the same idea in 4-5 sentences when it could have been conveyed through 2 sentences in a clear and concise way. So, that is where I got help from AI rather than implant its own idea of the case study into my report.

I think using AI did not have any significant changes to the content of my work and biased my views of it, because when I read through the case study and various source materials, I gained a clear moral understanding on what it was about, its effects and solutions. I strictly made sure to use AI just to support my writing and not influence my conscience. The final work is my own perspective of the case study and views but just written in the most efficient way.